when comparing Fagen to Bunck. For the latter two authors, the Cuban population's options are limited to accepting, or rejecting, attempts at cultural transformation from above. In Fernandes's account, the population is an active participant in an ongoing process of cultural creation, along with the state.

We should note, though, that Fernandes is studying popular culture in the Special Period. There have been few attempts to really investigate the nature and role of popular culture in Cuba between 1959 and the 1990s.

Fernandes argues that the Special Period, with the loss of the Soviet Union as an economic support and an ideological mooring, led to increased space for rethinking of culture from the bottom up. In this respect, a parallel process was going on in the popular arena as in the intellectual world.

Literature

According to literary scholar Roberto González Echevarría, "The Cuban Revolution is the dividing line in contemporary Latin American literature, a literature of before the revolution and one of after the revolution." In fact, he argues, "it is difficult to conceive of the Boom of the Latin American novel" if not for the Cuban Revolution. The heightened U.S. interest in Latin America sparked by the Revolution not only gave rise to the growth of Latin American Studies in the U.S. academy as discussed earlier, it also led to a proliferation of opportunities for Latin American authors in the United States, just as Cuba was pouring resources into creating its own literary institutions. The result was an unprecedented cornucopia for Latin American authors.[9]

Probably Cuba's most influential writer has been Alejo Carpentier, whose prolific career spanned the pre- and post-revolutionary periods until his death in 1980. Author of numerous works that have been widely translated, Carpentier also introduced the concept of "magical realism" into Latin American literature. In his prologue to his 1949 novel *El reino de este mundo* [*The Kingdom of this World*] Carpentier